INTRODUCTION TO SOCIOLOGY HUL 271

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Let’s begin with a question

- Why should engineering students do social sciences? What is the need?

SOME NEWS ITEMS FROM THE LAST YEAR

Let us see what we can learn about Sociology from these.

India’s Success in Women’s Sports

1/4/26, 11:17 AM Women defined Indian sport in a year of pause; now time to hit play

Women defined Indian sport in a year of pause; now time to hit play

After a quiet 2025, the coming year promises a flood of sporting events and sagas — a last World Cup clash for Messi

SPOTLIGHT

Wanted sons, unwanted daughters

India's gender preference still exists in homes, except that the conversations are now mostly behind closed doors and in online spaces. Hundreds of videos and products, all freely available online, promote sex selection, and have now come under the government scanner

Ashna Butani

Disclaimer: Sex determination is illegal and a punishable offence under the Pre-Conception (PC) and Pre-Natal Diagnostic Techniques (PNDT) Act.

"After having three daughters, my husband would get drunk and threaten me with divorce if I did not give him a son," says Delhi-based Pushpa (name changed to protect privacy). Then one day, 11 years later, when the tests revealed a male foetus, she was relieved.

This was 1993, a year before the Bill that would debar sex determination was passed. Parliament felt the need to formulate a law. In India's 1991 population Census, the sex ratio stood at 929 females for every 1,000 males.

A little over 30 years on, the family's internalised bias finds voice again, as

bearing age spend hours on the Internet trying to gauge the sex of their child. One such woman, who is 18 weeks pregnant, comments on a video of an influencer talking about 'signs' of a male foetus. The woman writes in the comment section in Hindi, "Ma'am, I have the same symptoms. I already have a daughter. Please pray for a baby boy."

In January 2025, the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare asked States and Union Territories to list URLs on e-commerce and social networking websites that promote sex determination.

The Ministry is responsible for the implementation of the Pre-Conception and Pre-Natal Diagnostic Techniques (Prohibition of Sex Selection) Act, 1994.

The video of the same influencer, with over 14 lakh views, demonstrating so-called signs for baby boys is on the Delhi Health Department's list of 45

Let her live: Pushpa (name changed), 61, was pressured to give birth to a boy in 1993. A retired creche worker, she notes that while couples don't talk about sex determination openly, they do so behind closed doors. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Premium

How the centuries-old Jodidara tradition is fading in Himachal's Trans-Giri region

Jodidara—a form of fraternal polyandry—has long been part of Hatti tribal culture in the Trans-Giri region of Himachal Pradesh and adjoining Uttarakhand. It is believed to have evolved to prevent division of ancestral land and maintain unity among brothers in the harsh, mountainous terrain.

Questions of death and dying

● BROSSEAU SAYS MENTAL ILLNESS HAS MADE HER LIFE UNBEARABLE, SHE WANTS A MEDICALLY ASSISTED DEATH; HER PSYCHIATRISTS ARE SPLIT OVER WHETHER SHE SHOULD BE GRANTED PERMISSION

Canadian comic artist Claire Brosseau seeks assisted death. Will govt let her?

Stephanie Nolen
Toronto, December 30

CLAIRE BROSSEAU is desperate to die.

She is 48 years old and has had a life she calls an "an embarrassment of riches." She has a vast network of friends, a devoted family, the steadfast adoration of a small dog. She has performed to raucous laughter in some of North America's most prestigious comedy clubs and festivals, acted in movies, written brutally funny television shows. She has travelled, shopped, danced and known herself to be deeply loved.

She also suffers from debilitating mental illness that decades of treatment have not tamed. Sometimes she is so crushingly sad that she sobs until her bones ache. Sometimes she feels as if she were standing on a ledge, flipping minute by minute between being sure that if she jumped she would actually fly, and wanting to hurl herself as hard as she can onto the ground.

She has tried more times than she can count to die by suicide.

In 2021, Brosseau, who lives in Toronto, learned of a coming change to Canadian law that would allow people who suffered with an incurable medical condition but were not near death to ask a doctor to end their life.

And she felt a small, tentative, tendril of relief. She could die in a way that did not involve pain or violence, or horror for the people who love her.

Nearly five years later, she's still alive — an inadvertent central player in an often-bitter public debate over who has the right to a medically assisted death in Canada. It is a controversy playing out with variations as more countries legalize assisted death and face the question of whether, and how, to expand it beyond people who are terminally ill.

Claire Brosseau at her apartment in Toronto, Canada. NYT

Thirty-four years ago, Brosseau was a 14-year-old honors student in Montreal with a wild streak, drinking, using drugs, having sex, and also sometimes turning abruptly cruel. Her alarmed parents took her to a psychotherapist who diagnosed manic depression. That was the start of the diagnoses: eating disorder, anxiety disorder, personality disorder, substance abuse disorder, chronic suicidal ideation and a whole plethora of other mental health issues. ("Not to brag," Brosseau says, the kind of deadpan, devastating aside that peppers her conversations.)

She tried at least 25 medications; two dozen different talk, art and behavioral therapies; dozens of rounds of electroconvulsive therapy (ECT); and guided psychedelics. She felt better, sometimes — for a while. But, relentlessly, they would return, the monsters that stalked her when she was awake and then moved into her dreams.

Despite everything she has put her body through, she is physically healthy. She might live decades more.

The change in the Canadian law meant she could have another option. In 2019, three years after the country legalized assisted death for people with a "reasonably foreseeable natural death," two people with chronic conditions went to court.

They argued that to exclude people with great suffering from incurable conditions who were not imminently dying was a violation of their right to equality before the law.

The courts agreed, and a new law in 2021 made eligible those people who were not at end of life.

Except for people whose sole chronic condition was mental illness. The government said it would delay including them for two years in order to draft special guidelines for assessing their eligibility. Of the nine countries that allow assisted death for people not at end of life, only Canada made this distinction for people with mental illness.

The exclusion was to end on March 17, 2023, and Brosseau planned to apply for an assisted death that day.

But as that date drew close, the government announced a further yearlong delay. Then, last year, another. NYT

NOT FOR SALE

SURAT FAMILY COURT GRANTED INTERIM RELIEF TO THE PETITIONING FATHER

7-year-old's initiation into Jain monkhood 'on hold'

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EXPRESS OPINION

BECAUSE THE TRUTH INVOLVES US ALL

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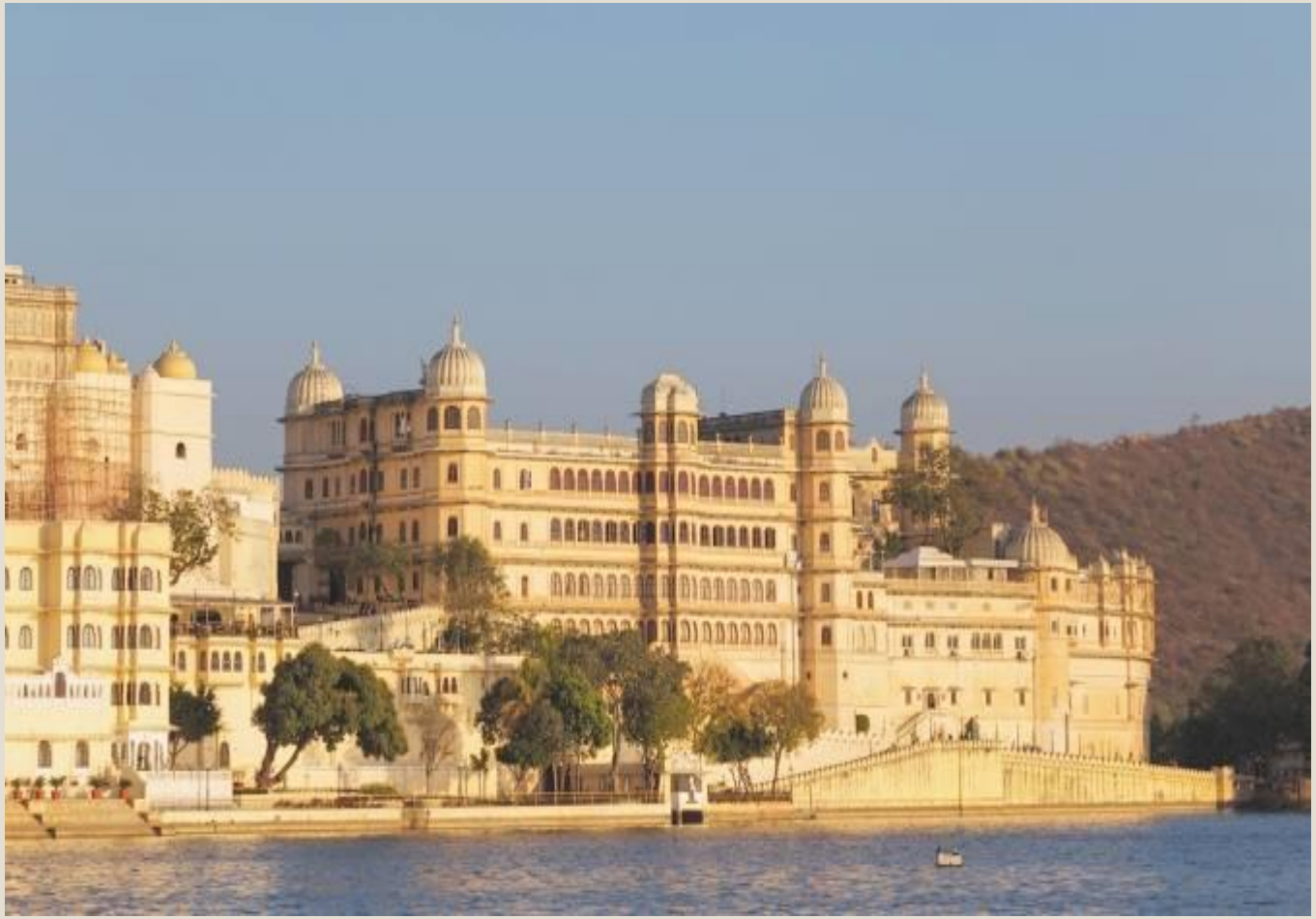
Bridging the gender gap

- Claudia Goldin's (an Economist and the winner of Nobel Prize 2023) work on Career and Family used insights from History and Sociology to understand women's participation in the US labor markets.

How I began to see Sociology unfold around me?

- Let me share.

I grew up in this city-



- In addition to being a tourist place, it has been in news for something else for over decades now.
- Guess what is that.

- As a destination for celebrity weddings.
- What does it tell us about wealth, consumption and class?

In the mid-1960s, amid famine-like con- scheme was rolled out across the state.

The writer is a Pune-based economist

stitution, but because it is enshrined in India's civilisation.

Wedding excess and marriage essence

ON THE LOOSE

BY LEHER KALA

TWO MAMMOTH weddings in Delhi recently upped the ever-expanding universe of glittering consumption to further absurdity. Instagram was overrun with reels of how one host hired a stadium for a concert by pop star Arijit Singh, while at the other, guests swayed in their finery to an electric performance by AP Dhillon. Conservative estimates suggest both weddings easily cost upwards of Rs 150 crores each, to be sure, small change for these industrialist families. Who knows, maybe what keeps the super wealthy committed to the splashy extravaganza are the expectations of those lower down the pecking order, lesser mortals caught up in striving and self-optimisation, stuck on the elusive search for the best life. When somebody has the means to live the dream, don't they have a responsibility to share some of that Cristal champagne and Michelin-star chef created magic, with their merely solvent friends and family? After all, it's everyone's fantasy, to be so wealthy as to be insulated from the drudgeries of life.

As a guest at a big fat Indian wedding, for a few magical days at least one may live as a participant in the Gilded Age, or a character on *Succession*, where money is used as protection from consequence. The hard up son-in-law on *Succession* compares being rich with being a superhero and shudders at a $5 million inheritance, calling it a "nightmare". Because it's simply not enough to truly live it up, the paltry sum described by another of the scions on the show with a wine analogy, as the difference between "regular decanting" and "hyper decanting". Ah, the infinite joy derived from observing the peccadilloes of the 1%! However, it is worth noting, when billionaires put their money in trust funds and fixed deposits to earn fat amounts in compounding interest, it isn't doing anyone else much good. Much better then, when they go all out for explosive style—the *phoolwala*, caterer, entertainers and *tentwalas* benefit, not to mention the hosts' own overall net gain in social capital.

Consumption, when wildly over the top, is a euphemism for soft power.

Social media brought the Bezos and Ambani nuptials into every drawing room. Suddenly, for the rest of the world, contemporary weddings are less about sanctifying a union and more about getting the hashtag right. But people are people. The common factor between the guest dripping in diamonds and the scrambling wannabe trying to make sense of so much sparkling bounty is existential ennui — everyone's trying to wring some last bit of wonder from life — the eternal question being that if we were a thousand times richer, would we be a thousand times happier? These are philosophical quandaries that have surfaced throughout history. Initially, thriving depended more on a larger community but over millennium, the human pursuit of one-upmanship became as important as chasing happiness. Perhaps, the world has to go full circle to come to the conclusion that flourishing involves equal measures of health, wealth and some luck; and time for self cultivation is as important as for amassing riches.

When a wedding is too over-the-top, it almost feels like the host is trying to buy a guarantee of a successful marriage. Alas, an Instagram-worthy show doesn't always equal a fairy-tale ending. If anything, the messy realities of marriage may feel especially deflating, after a spectacular beginning. Marriage is a serious business, a rite of passage, along with birth and death. While a birth provides a sense of purpose and a death provokes introspection on the ultimate realities of life, modern marriages can be narcissistic displays of fancy destinations, exotic jewellery and sweeping tulle outfits. Of course, it is a momentous occasion but there's something shallow about so much emphasis on creating the perfectly orchestrated event. A humbling reminder, the complications of *getting* married are nothing compared to the complications of *staying* married.

The writer is director, Hutkay Films

COPY

Traditional Authority?

- What does a huge turn out at the funeral of an erstwhile Royal tell us about authority?
- An even greater turnout at the *'Rajtilak'* of the successor to the throne of Mewar?
- What makes people look forward to different forms of authority?

Aravali Hills

- How can we understand the recent protests about a new definition of what constitutes Aravali Hills?(the SC has put a stay on that definition)
- How can we think about this in terms of French Sociologist Durkheim's ideas of 'collective consciousness'?

Topics we shall cover

Week	Topics
1-2	Introduction to the course; What is Sociology; Sociological Imagination; Self and Society
3-5	Emergence of Sociology as a discipline; Sociology and Common Sense; Macro and Micro Sociology; Sociology and other Social Sciences; Theoretical Perspectives in Sociology
6-8	Karl Marx; Emile Durkheim; Max Weber (Alienation, Anomie and Disenchantment)
9-11	Mental Health; Race; Gender
12-13	Globalization; Ageing
14	Disability; Summing up

Assessment and Evaluation

Evaluation Component	**Weightage (%)**
Mid Term	30
End Term	30
Review assignment	10
Group Assignment	20
Tutorials	10

Some ground rules for the class

- Let us set these up together?

Bridging the gender gap

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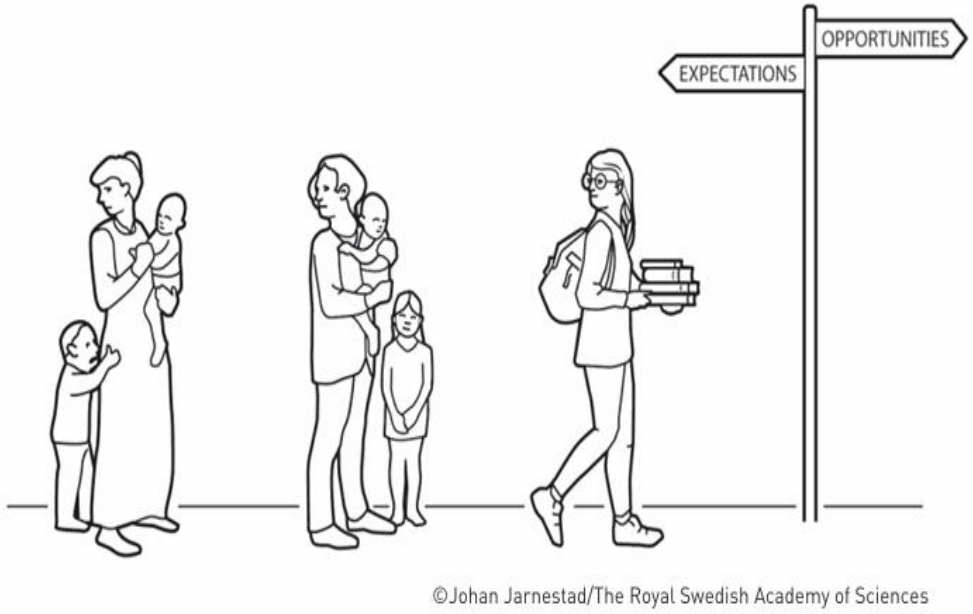
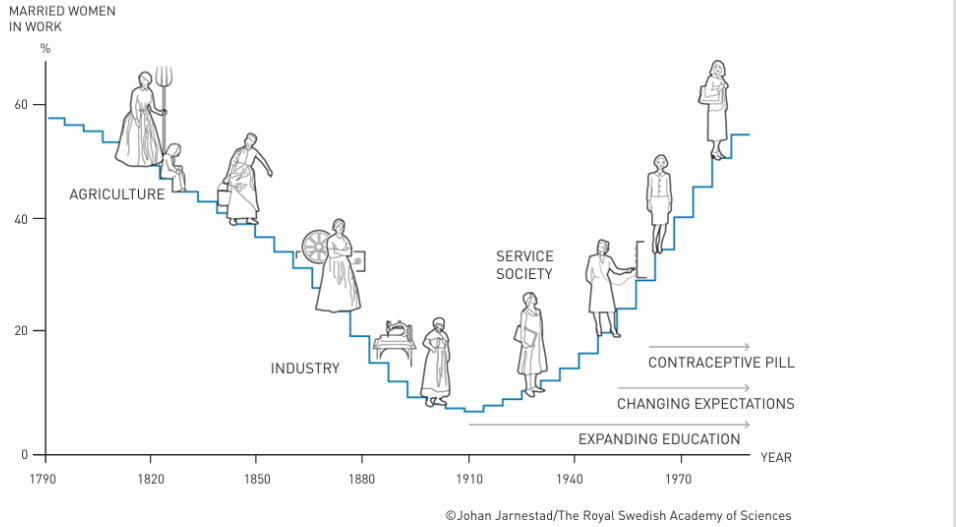
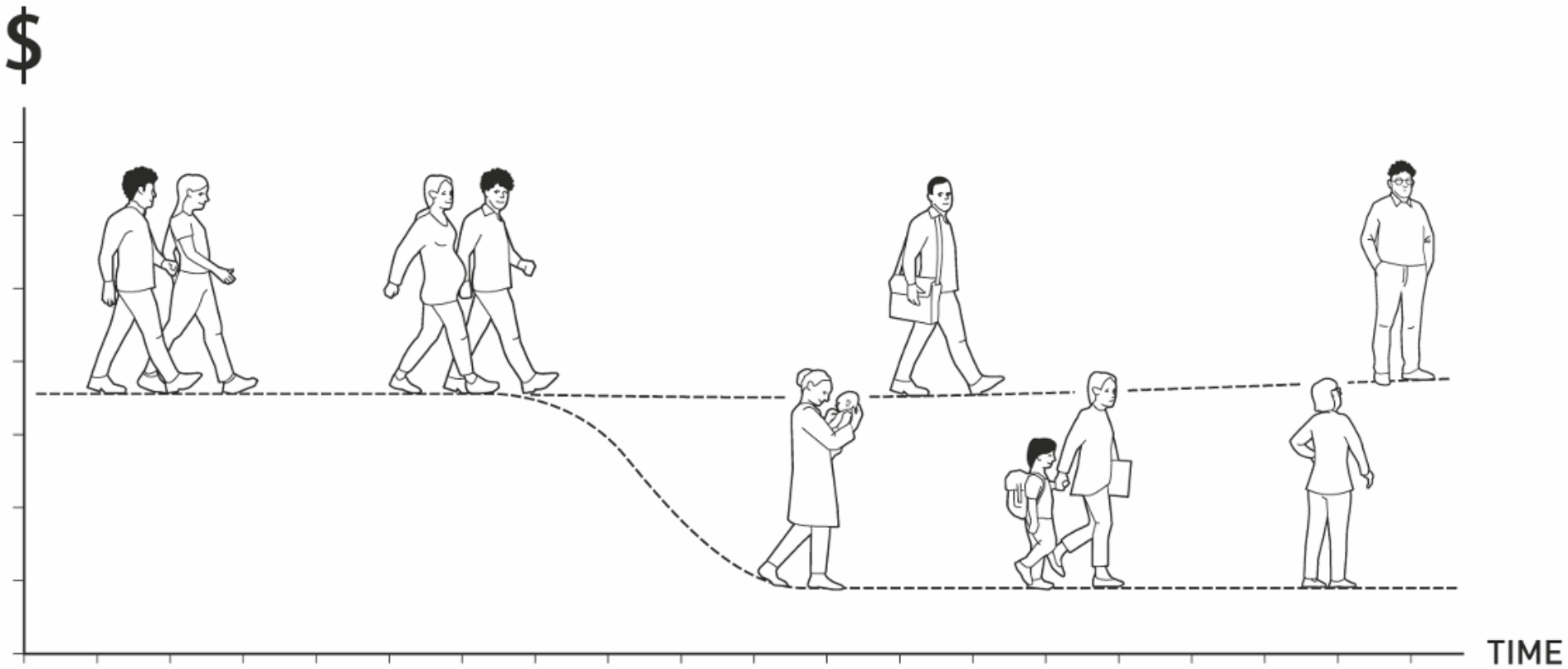




https://www.nobelprize.org/prizes/economic-sciences/2023/press-release/



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SOCIOLOGICAL PERSPECTIVE

Week 1

- What is sociological perspective?
- Sociology as a systematic study of (human) society.

- Sociological perspective differs from other forms of knowledge.
- While other forms of knowledge that we have may be important, the sociologists investigate society using a *sociological perspective*- how do we do that?

- What about human and non-humans? And what do those relationships tell us about the society?

Developing a Sociological perspective

- We look for patterns- *Seeing the general in the particular*.
- *Seeing the strange in familiar* (debunking taken for granted ways of looking at the world)- look at everyday taken for granted aspects as strange and unpack them.

- Seeing society in our everyday lives. Example?
- Some situations, more than others, help us see how society shape individual lives- *living on the margins and living through the crisis*. What does that mean?
- Examples?
- Therefore, to equip ourselves with a sociological perspective, we must take a step back from what is familiar to us and be more curious!
- Times of social change leads to sociological thinking, and sociological thinking can bring about social change.

Developing a Global Perspective

- Why is having a global perspective important for sociology? (e.g. What does Australia's FB ban for children tell us about children/teenagers and their vulnerability in cyberspace)
- Different countries and people's life chances.
- Where we live shapes the lives we live.
- Changes in one place can have far reaching global effects (Vulture crisis in India).
- Thinking globally helps us learn more about ourselves.

- So how does having a sociological perspective then can be helpful?

- Society shapes (structures) us but we are merely at the receiving end?
- Sociology investigates the connections between what society makes of us and what we make of society and ourselves. Our activities both structure – or give shape to the social world around us and, at the same time, are structured by that world.
- The social contexts of our lives are not completely random events but are structured, or patterned, in distinct ways.

The Agency Structure Relationship

- *Structure and Agency*
- Human societies are always in process of *structuration* (Giddens 1984)and structures change. (e.g. uprisings against authoritarian regimes)

- Agency- gives importance to individual actions- the **agent** as having power for action.
- However, individuals are also part of social structures by which they are constrained. E.g. student- university.

Three theoretical traditions in Sociology

- Theories are ways of explaining society. Theorising about society means constructing interpretation of events using statements that explain a wide variety of empirical situations. It is a statement of different facts are related.
- We need to assemble evidence in order to theorise.

Structural-Functional Approach

- Sees society as complex system whose parts work together to promote solidarity and stability.
- Functionalism emphasises the importance of moral consensus in maintaining order and stability.
- The approach looks at a structure's social function- what are the consequences of any social pattern for the operation of society as a whole?
- Social structures like families, workplace, classrooms- what are their social functions?
- Herbert Spencer was a functionalist who compared society to the human body- various structures of the society are like various organs.
- *Manifest and latent functions; functions and dysfunctions* (Robert Merton)

- This approach's influence has declined- by focusing on social stability and unity, what has been ignored?

Conflict theories/Social Conflict Approach

- Reject functionalism's emphasis on consensus; instead conflict theorists highlight social divisions and focus on issues of power, inequality and struggle.
- Using this approach, sociologists investigate how factors like social class, race, gender, ability (disability), aging are linked to society's unequal distribution
- Such theorists tend to see society as composed of distinct groups, each pursuing its own interests which means there is always potential for conflict.
- Karl Marx's ideas have been influential in conflict theories though not all conflict theories are Marxist.
- Feminism, for instance, draws attention to issues that were previously ignored by sociologists. Feminists focused on women's subordinate position; work at both micro and macro level.
- Race conflict approaches; caste conflict approaches- focuses on inequality between people of different racial categories (as well as caste categories).

Symbolic Interactionism

- The previous approaches focused on larger social structures, this focuses of micro level interaction.
- This approach is a *framework that sees society as the product of the everyday interactions of individuals.*
- Directs our attention to the details of interpersonal interaction and role interactions play in creating society.
- Society is a shared reality that people construct for themselves as they interact with one another.
- We have symbols-symbols have meanings; we create our reality, as we define our world, decide what we think about others.
- How we understand our consciousness, self and behaviour is a product of social processes- specifically interaction and communication- we become humans by our interaction with others.
- Social act- 'joint action' (Blumer); interpretive understanding of people's action; sense of self.

- Max Weber, GH Mead, Erving Goffman.

Major Theoretical Approaches

	Structural-Functional Approach	Social-Conflict Approach	Symbolic-Interaction Approach
What is the level of analysis?	Macro-level	Macro-level	Micro-level
What image of society does the approach have?	Society is a system of interrelated parts that is relatively stable. Each part works to keep society operating in an orderly way. Members generally agree about what is morally right and morally wrong.	Society is a system of social inequalities based on class (Marx), gender (feminism and gender-conflict approach), and race (race-conflict approach). Society operates to benefit some categories of people and harm others. Social inequality causes conflict that leads to social change.	Society is an ongoing process. People interact in countless settings using symbolic communications. The reality people experience is variable and changing.
What core questions does the approach ask?	How is society held together? What are the major parts of society? How are these parts linked? What does each part do to help society work?	How does society divide a population? How do advantaged people protect their privileges? How do disadvantaged people challenge the system seeking change?	How do people experience society? How do people shape the reality they experience? How do behavior and meaning change from person to person and from one situation to another?

Source: Sociology (John Macionis, 2016)

The changing nature of social world- and Sociology

- Technology and human interaction (turning to AI chatbots for help)
- Digital World
- Globalisation
- Consumption

Sociology's Purpose- science or social reform?

- Sociology's founders wanted to develop the 'science of society'; they were concerned about the problems of their times.
- Use of scientific methods to understand problems to suggest ways of reforming society.
- Scientific research- social reform are not necessarily distinct.
- Distinction between being pure scientists and reformist.
- What problems are worthy of study? Who decides?
- 'Scientific views' about race, gender- what do they lead to?

For the next class

- Read Sociological Imagination (C Wright Mills), chapter 1 “The Promise” for the next class.